London (Blake): close reading with tiny quotes

Year 8 English Language · Skill: the smallest quote | About 30 minutes, by hand | Name: _____ Date: _____

London, William Blake, 1794 (first two verses). Read it twice. Then do the tasks.

I wander thro' each charter'd street,
Near where the charter'd Thames does flow,
And mark in every face I meet
Marks of weakness, marks of woe.

In every cry of every Man,
In every Infant's cry of fear,
In every voice, in every ban,
The mind-forg'd manacles I hear.

A · Find the tiny quotes (5 min) [3 marks]

For each point, write the **smallest** quote from the poem that proves it: **three words or fewer**.

Point	My tiny quote
Suffering is everywhere in the city	
People are trapped, but not by chains	
Even the river is owned or controlled	

B · Quote, effect, So What (10 min) [6 marks]

Row 1 is done as a model. Complete rows 2 and 3. In row 3 choose any tiny quote you like.

Tiny quote	Effect on the reader (a feeling or idea)	So What (what does Blake want us to think?)
“every”	Repeated five times, it makes the suffering feel endless, as if no one escapes.	This suggests Blake wants us to see that misery belongs to the whole society, not a few people.
“charter'd”		

C · One paragraph (12 min) [8 marks]

How does Blake present life in the city in these two verses? Use **three tiny quotes** (three words or fewer each). Label each sentence **Q** (quote), **E** (effect), **SW** (So What) in the margin. Start with your answer to the question.

D · Shrink it (2 min) [1 mark]

Look at your longest quote in the paragraph. Rewrite it as small as it can be and still prove your point.

Self-check (5 min)

- ☐ Every quote is **three words or fewer**. I tried cutting one more word from each.
- ☐ Each effect names a **feeling or an idea** (not just "Blake uses repetition").
- ☐ Each So What says what Blake **wants us to think**, and follows from the quote.
- ☐ My first sentence answers the question, not just describes the poem.

Oral check (5 min, with a parent)

Say it out loud, from memory if you can. Parent asks: **"So what is Blake trying to make us feel about the city?" (She answers with one tiny quote, out loud.)**

Parent tick: ☐ answered without reading it ☐ answered with a prompt ☐ could not yet

Weekly review (for J, 5 min)

Did her quotes get shorter than last week?	
What was weak this week?	
What worked?	
Time taken (HTML / written / total)	
One change for next week	

Parent key and what to look for

Word meanings (all Year 8 can handle): *charter'd*: mapped, licensed, owned (the idea of controlled by trade and rules). *ban*: a ban, or a curse. *manacles*: handcuffs or shackles. *mind-forg'd*: made by the mind. *marks*: visible signs; also “notice”.

A (possible): everywhere: “every”; trapped by the mind: “mind-forg'd manacles”; owned or controlled: “charter'd”. Other good tiny quotes: “marks” (repeated, as if everyone is branded), “weakness”, “woe”, “cry”, “fear”.

B model for “charter'd”: *Effect:* Calling a free-flowing river “charter'd” makes even nature seem owned and controlled. *So What:* This suggests that Blake wants us to feel that money and rules reach into everything, leaving nothing free.

What a stronger paragraph looks like:

Sign	Stronger	Weaker
Quote	1 to 3 words, exactly the word that does the work	A whole line
Effect	A feeling or idea (“endless”, “trapped”)	Names a technique only
So What	What Blake wants us to think, grounded in the quote	A new idea the quote does not support

Level cue (AQA-style): work that names the technique and a general effect sits at “some” to “clear”. Work that uses a tiny quote precisely and says what the writer wants us to think moves towards “perceptive”.

Does she move on? Not yet. The English plan needs her quotes to get shorter and her effects to name a feeling or idea, over more than one piece.